

Cheating and plagiarism

Because of its obvious deviation from the standard route, e-courses are very prone to cheating and plagiarism incidents. A student can easily hire a “proxy” to complete the required coursework. While there are measures (such as software) in place to prevent such incidents from happening, they aren’t foolproof and cheaters are often able to find a workaround. Several incidents of plagiarism have been reported by students at Coursera during the peer grading process.

Unregulated and non-standardised components

With the plethora of online learning options now available, there’s a dire need for some sort of standardisation and regulation across the various platforms at students’ disposal. A student may be enrolled for a couple of courses at Coursera and a couple more at Udacity or another such portal. Each course at each of these portals has its own unique structure and give-backs such as syllabus and college credit. In such a case, it’s really difficult for a student to take back something valuable from his e-learning experience since s/he will have to juggle between multiple syllabi and radically different course structures. Course syllabus is rarely regulated and there is, until date, no set standard for grading and feedback. While it’s tough to create a standard for a project so massive in scale, there could still be a consistent method of grading so that a student can gauge his performance with equal measure across different e-schools.

The bigger picture

While it’s still early to gauge the large scale impact of online learning on society as a whole, sceptics argue that e-learning can alter the entire landscape of learning and not necessarily in a progressive way. The success of MOOCs could force institutions to set up similar projects and while that may be feasible in a few regions, it’s a seemingly impossible task in a country like India, which is constantly dealing with a faculty crunch and dearth of skilled labour. In a survey conducted, almost 80% of the surveyed institutions said that they either had no plans or were undecided about setting up a MOOC system. Close to 60% of surveyed professors confessed that the growth of online education scared them instead of inducing excitement. These statistics suggest that while a considerable number have lapped up the idea of online education, those in charge of the institutional setup are not totally gung-ho about it. Professors devoting time to help set up an